

MGT 412R: New Venture Design

Exec Weekend

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INSTRUCTOR

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COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course is the foundational elective to begin shaping your MBA for a career based upon Innovation, Design, or Entrepreneurship. Along with *MGT 452: New Product Development*, it forms the core of the Certificate in Design & Innovation. For those looking to fully prepare their startup to launch post-MBA, it is a prerequisite for *MGT 415: New Venture Development*.

The course will provide experience in transforming an understanding of user need, a company's strategic intent, and the scientific or technological innovation to which the company has access, into viable new lines of business or ventures that bring desirable and profitable new offerings to the world. The course will provide an introduction to the user-based, strategic and operational aspects of sparking an innovation and developing it into a product or service that people will love, as a competitive and sustainable business.

Traditional business planning has generally approached this challenge in a top-down manner, in the sense of being driven by the company's motivations, capabilities, or vision of the future. The newer practice of Design Thinking frames the process as one driven from below. Vital insights as to people's needs and wants are gathered through primary research, and the company takes its direction from the people it serves.

In actual practice, successful companies pursue a hybrid top-down and bottom-up approach, though often without framing this as an explicit process, or even realizing that they are doing so. We will learn the tools that help do this, explore their utility and boundaries, and place them in the context of an overarching framework.

The course follows a **"hybrid" online + in-person format**, with three online modules in Canvas, and three in-person class sessions at Rady, alternating online / in-person. Additionally, teams will meet individually with the instructor twice, once between the first and second in-person sessions and again between the second and third in-person sessions, for focused coaching and critique as they develop their concepts and final presentations.

Course materials are a mix of case studies, readings, multimedia, and practical exercises. Online assignments are meant to provide the flexibility for students and teams to adapt workflow to their own

schedules, with due dates to ensure that materials are available as needed for peer feedback, instructor feedback, and whole-class discussion.

The peer feedback and whole-class discussion assignments are a vital part of the learning process, because, as managers after graduation, you will need to evaluate and critique the work of others on your team and across the organization, as well as contributing your own work. Active participation is vital, as much of this can only be learned by doing.

There is a final project, in which student teams will develop a concept that forms the basis of a new line of business, and the accompanying explanation of why this is a compelling offering from the customer's perspective and a compelling opportunity from the business' perspective. We will help you initiate, develop, and refine your concept using the practical exercises throughout the course, and you will present your final concept pitch to the entire class in the third in-person session.

For those students pursuing a startup idea, the team you form and concept you explore this quarter does **not** need to continue into the Winter *New Venture Development* course - many students discover better opportunities and form stronger teams as a result of their experience in this course, and you are absolutely free to pursue those. Others find value in learning the essential tools using a "practice" idea – one free from the preconceptions and assumptions they may have accumulated.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

New Venture Design is an exercise in learning by practical application. This course will ground your approach in the realities of market and user need, and sharpen your ability to craft and articulate both opportunity and solution. By the end of this course, you will be able to:

1. Analyze the factors that focus a company's innovation and new offering development efforts, to articulate a best focus for these efforts, along with a supporting rationale.
2. Perform actual user and market research, analyze the findings, and synthesize to uncover and articulate deep insight as to the users' needs. Combine this with other relevant data to highlight opportunities for new offerings.
3. Construct and articulate viable and compelling positioning for the new offerings and concepts, in order to clarify, communicate, and guide further work.
4. Prototype, test, and refine concepts, to create real value for your customer and to deliver that value through an excellent customer experience.
5. Craft and present a compelling business case, expressing the opportunity, concept, and rationale with an appropriate level of tangibility and specificity.

In summary, this course will refresh, refine, and extend the knowledge, skills, and ability gained in the core curriculum, with an emphasis on uncovering unique insights and opportunities that can drive the creation of new lines of business. The course will push you to go beyond superficial recognitions or merely interesting ideas, and craft offerings that are both compelling and viable.

COURSE ASSIGNMENTS

See grading criteria and schedule.

COURSE GRADING

Your performance will be evaluated as follows:

Component	Percentage
Teamwork	10 %
Class Participation (Online and In-Person)	20 %
Practical Exercises and Submissions	30 %
Team Project Presentation (Presented in final session)	40 %

Attendance: In the MBA curriculum, it is very difficult to make up for an absence, due to the cumulative building of understanding across the sessions we have together. At the same time, we all have busy personal and professional lives. The online modules provide you the flexibility to shift your coursework time commitments to better match your personal and professional time commitments.

You are expected to attend each of the three in-person class sessions, and you are responsible for the material covered the in-person class sessions whether or not you attend. However, we realize that despite your best efforts you might be forced to miss a class due to unforeseen emergencies. Makeup for the session will depend upon the material covered. Because of our reliance on practical exercises and team work, you should realize that an absence affects classmates as well.

Teamwork: Businesses expect their people to tackle important projects in teams. We will use surveys and direct observation to gauge the effectiveness of your collaboration on team project work in the course, to provide feedback and to assess 10% of your course grade.

Class Participation: Your class participation (contribution to in-person class discussions and online forum discussions) will count for 20% of the class grade. To help in preparation, we have suggested "Guiding Questions" for every topic in the detailed syllabus and on Canvas. These questions should serve merely as a starting point.

At the beginning of the class, one or more class members will be asked to start the session by addressing a specific question, or by providing an overview of the reading / preparatory exercise. Anyone who has prepared the case or done the exercise should be able to handle such a leadoff assignment. After a few minutes of initial analysis and recommendations, we will open the discussion to the rest of the class. As a group we will try to build a complete analysis of the situation. Online discussions follow a similar flow in an asynchronous format, kicked off by pre-prepared materials (video, diagram, presentation, etc) submitted as part of an associated exercise.

You are expected to be an active participant throughout the entire class or online forum, and to contribute to the quality of the discussion. Please note that the frequency (i.e., the quantity) of your interventions in class is

not a key criterion for effective class contribution. Some criteria used to evaluate class contribution are as follows:

- Is the participant an active listener, looking for opportunities to enrich the discussion?
- Are the points that are made relevant to the discussion? Are they linked to the comments of others?
- Do the comments show evidence of analysis of the case / reading / exercise?
- Is there willingness to test new ideas, or are all comments "safe"? (For example, repetition of case facts without analysis and conclusions.)
- Do comments clarify or build upon the important aspects of earlier comments and lead to a clearer understanding of the case / reading / exercise?

Practical Exercises: Innovation and New Venture Creation are cross-functional, time-sensitive, and competitive. As a result, leading-edge techniques are constantly being generated and refined, and most practitioners learn by doing. We will use individual and team exercises as a teaching tool, and to provide information for the final team project. There is no "right" answer for these, but because some of the exercises require outside prep, and because the individual contributions form the basis of a collective learning experience, we will be evaluating your preparation, intensity of application, and thoughtfulness of execution. Your participation in the practical exercises will count for 30% of the class grade.

Team Project: There will be a team deliverable due the last class session which will count for a total of 40% of the class grade. It is intended to take you through an Innovation / New Venture Creation cycle, though it is compacted to be manageable within the constraints of a university course and your professional schedules. The topic will be the concept you develop over the quarter, and the practical exercises will serve to provide some baseline information to inform the development of this concept and pitch.

We will expect your team to:

- further supplement this with additional research,
- synthesize an understanding of the environment of use,
- uncover opportunities and imperatives for a new product / service in that space,
- prototype critical elements of the new product / service, and
- communicate to the rest of us the vision for the product, and why it is compelling for both user and business.

The final deliverables are in two parts, graded together:

- A 5 minute in-class presentation to the class and instructors, and
- A report on the project in written format, which may be your presentation materials, if they are sufficiently complete.
- Please remember that quality, not quantity, is the key to success in the project.

We may set aside some class meeting time for team project work, and we will be available for consultations and work sessions with the teams. We are happy to help guide and critique your work along the way.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:
<http://academicintegrity.ucsd.edu/process/policy.html>.

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) Policy and Approach

Generative AI is a disruptive force in both business and education. While many choose to focus on the negative aspects of disruption, leaders of Design and Innovation teams recognize that the disruption of established systems and competitive dynamics also creates opportunities for those who are able to harness the new tools and master the new landscapes created as a result. This is the essence of the concept “Disruptive Innovation” at the heart of Clayton Christensen’s seminal work *The Innovator’s Dilemma*.

We also know from the history of technological advances in design and manufacturing that new tools tend to improve both quality and speed of work for the thoughtful user, and shift the thoughtful adopter’s focus to the higher-value creative and intellectual tasks. Thoughtless (and non-) adopters become obsolete.

The assignments in this course do not lend themselves to simply “having ChatGPT do it;” I know this from experiments we have run in previous quarters of this course. There are, however, elements that we can learn to accomplish better or faster by treating generative AI as an assistant to our work, which further helps us develop our ability to critique and guide innovation work, critical managerial skills. There are also examples of good process that a custom agent can model for us to help us learn to use good process. You will have an opportunity to experience this firsthand through exercises during our in-person sessions and through custom agents I have created for your use in this course, such as the *NPD Ideation Assistant*.

To help us advance our ability to use AI as an effective tool and to identify ineffective uses of AI, I allow its use in this course under the following conditions: **Cite and Critique**.

Cite: Identify which AI tool you used, and for what task(s). Save and forward the prompt and output.

Critique: Give your assessment of how helpful the tool was to you and your team. Identify how it could have been more helpful. I will synthesize these learnings for the class as a whole.

This applies both to any tools you discover and to the custom tools and agents I supply for your use.

COURSE SCHEDULE

The course is arranged to generally follow the flow of activities in a typical Innovation and New Venture Creation cycle, with some adjustment to allow for exercises that must be prepared ahead outside of class. It is “front-loaded,” to ensure that students have the tools needed for the final project. This gives us some flexibility in the final session to explore specific topics in greater detail. Depending upon feedback from the class, we can explore topics that expand our range of understanding, such as organizational issues for Innovation and New Venture Creation within large / small / entrepreneurial organizations, process differences in software and biotech/pharma, etc. We actively solicit your input on this.

Videos, readings, and online exercises are posted on Canvas, arranged in modules that you must complete before the in-person session that concludes each module. Allow some time for this – it is impossible to “binge watch” the day before and successfully complete the online exercises.

Setup	Topics and Preparation
Team Formation	The team you form for this quarter is only for this quarter. If you plan to take either <i>MGT 452: New Product Development</i> or <i>MGT 415: New Venture Development</i> later this academic year, you may choose to continue working together, or you may choose to form or join another team. That is entirely up to you. All of the assignments in the first Online Module are individual assignments; you will start working as a team at the first In-Person Session at the end of Week 2. However, you should not delay forming a team, as there is much to accomplish together between the first and second in-person sessions. You will likely find it helpful to participate in the team-finding discussion forums on Canvas. These will remain open until the In-Person Session at the end of Week 2.

Online Module 1	Topics and Assignments
Course Intro	• View my video welcome to the course. • View my video explaining the structure and intent of the course, and the different types of activities. • View my video introductions, and why you even care. • View our TA’s video introductions of themselves If this seems like a lot of video to watch, please know that we follow best practices of online coursework, limiting videos to a maximum of 5-10 minutes, with activities or readings between the videos to reinforce the learnings.

The Expanding Airport	• View my video setting the context of <i>The Expanding Airport</i> film. • View the film <i>The Expanding Airport</i>. As you watch, consider these questions from the perspective of the intended audience: ◦ What is my first reaction to this film? ◦ What questions does the film raise for me? • Contribute your reactions and questions to the online discussion forum. Read through your classmates' contributions and engage in discussion. • As you engage in discussion, consider and contribute: ◦ Is there an overarching theme(s) in the discussion? ◦ What have the designers accomplished with this film? ◦ Can you pull out specific examples from the film, of techniques that seemed particularly effective? It may help to consider: ▪ What they have communicated in this part of the film? ▪ How have they communicated this? ▪ Why was it important to communicate this point in this way? • View my video wrap-up, summarizing the lessons learned from the film and how they apply to the New Venture Creation process.
Mars Rover / Seven Minutes of Terror	• View my video setting the context of <i>Seven Minutes of Terror</i>, which describes the process NASA used to get the Mars Curiosity Rover to the surface of Mars. • View the video <i>Seven Minutes of Terror</i>. As you watch, consider these questions from the perspective of the rest of NASA: ◦ What was the sequence of events to get Curiosity to the surface of Mars? ◦ How did they convince NASA that this is the best plan? ◦ How did they even come up with this solution in the first place? ◦ Did the team have some key insight that drove their solution? • Contribute your thoughts and observations to the online discussion forum. Read through your classmates' contributions and engage in discussion.
Product I Hate	• View my video introduction to this exercise. • Craft and upload a video about a product you actually own that just irritates you. Show and describe in a maximum of two minutes exactly why this is. Be sure to use the offending product as a visual aid. • Some prompts to consider: ◦ Does it fail to deliver what it promises? ◦ Does it not understand how to fit into your life? ◦ Is there something else that makes you hate it? • View 10 of your classmates' videos. Which 10 to view is entirely your choice. ◦ What themes or patterns do you see in what makes a "hate-able" product? • Contribute to the online discussion forum on the themes and patterns you noticed. • View my video wrap-up of the exercise.

Design Thinking	View my video explaining the characteristics of high-performing teams, and the development and application of the Double-Diamond process of Design Thinking.
Ideation	View my video explaining the origin and conduct of the modern, formalized brainstorming process, its use in the various stages of New Venture Creations, and the specialized application of Mind-Mapping.
Food Photos	- View my video explaining the assignment. - Photograph all the places you store, prepare, use, or consume food. Bring the photographs to the next In-Person Session in a shareable form – we will use them in an exercise.
Team Formation	Participate in the online forum and team mixer as an aid to finding teammates and forming a team to work on a Concept through the quarter, leading to the final presentation. The ideal team size is 4-5 people.

In-Person Session 1 End of Week 2 10 Oct 26	Topics and Preparation
	We will provide details and guidance, and lead exercises and discussions live in the classroom. Be sure that you have completed all of Online Module 1.
Team Formation	By now you should have a team to work with on developing a Concept over the course of this quarter. This does not have to be the basis of your work in <i>MGT 415: New Venture Development</i> or <i>MGT 452: New Product Development</i> , if you choose to pursue either course. You may change topics and/or teams when you begin the Winter quarter.
Design Thinking Exercise	We will conduct an in-class exercise to explore the practical applications of Design Thinking. Be sure that you have viewed / reviewed the video in Module 1.
Food Photos	We will conduct an in-class exercise to explore the practical applications and analysis of user research to derive insights.
Brainstorm / Mind Map Exercise	We will conduct an in-class exercise to explore the practical applications of Brainstorming and Mind-Mapping. Be sure that you have viewed / reviewed the video in Module 1.

Team Project Ideas / Concepts	In your teams, you will begin to apply the tools we are learning to find opportunities and generate ideas for your own team project. You will continue building upon this in Module 1.

Online Module 2	Topics and Assignments
Team Project Ideas / Concepts	- Continue working as a team to find opportunities and generate ideas for your own team project. - Write a description of your 3 most promising ideas or opportunities. - Craft a video, maximum 2 minutes, to accompany your description. - Upload both to Canvas for peer and instructor feedback. - Review and critique 1 other team's submission. - You may choose which team to critique. We suggest you pick teams whose Concept is interesting to you, or to which you can bring helpful expertise. - Your team may also invite classmates with relevant expertise to provide critique as their choices. - Once you have chosen, you must continue with this same team in follow-on critique exercises for the rest of this quarter. This continuity helps you to give better critique and allows you to see the effect of your critique as the team's Concept evolves. - Use the rubric attached to the assignment in Canvas to guide your critique. Instructors will synthesize and provide feedback.
"Concept" - Process, Progress, Critique	View my video discussing the realities of progress towards a Concept, and critiquing an example from prior years.
Focusing Function	- View my video developing the Focusing Function, illustrating it in relation to the exercises of In-Person Session 1, discuss its application in real life, and introducing the Tesla exercise. - Apply the focusing function to your assigned Tesla scenario, create a document summarizing your analysis and action plan, and upload to Canvas. - Review and critique your chosen team's submission. Instructors will synthesize and provide feedback.
Customer Journey Maps	- View my video introducing the topic of Service Design, and explaining the importance, use, and construction of Personas. - View my video introducing the Customer Journey Map, and explaining how to research and construct an effective Customer Journey Map.

Drive-Thru Exercise	• View my video introducing and explaining the Drive-Thru Exercise. • In your project teams, conduct primary qualitative research to document the fast-food drive-thru experience, • Create video, maximum 4 minutes, to document your findings, insights, and opportunities. Upload to Canvas for peer critique. • Create a Customer Journey Map to document your findings, insights, and opportunities. Upload to Canvas for peer critique. • View and critique your chosen team's submission. Use the rubric attached to the assignment in Canvas to guide your critique. In particular, ask yourself: ◦ Do you agree with the opportunities the team has identified? ◦ How well does the Customer Journey Map represent the research findings in the video? • Participate in the online discussion forum synthesizing our learnings from the Drive-Thru Exercise. Ask yourself: ◦ What patterns do I see in the Customer Experience of fast-food drive-thru? ◦ What patterns do I see in how effectively and accurately teams apply Customer Journey Mapping to assess and communicate the Customer Experience?
Service Blueprints	• View my video introducing the Service Blueprint, and explaining how to research and construct one, linking to and building from the Customer Journey Map.
Harley-Davidson	• View my video setting the context for the case and explaining the associated participant analysis assignment. • In your project team, prepare a presentation, maximum 10 minutes, on your assigned participant, their relationship with Harley, and product opportunities that would be compelling to this one participant, based upon your insights. Upload your slides to Canvas, be prepared to present live in the next In-Person Session.
Value Proposition and Positioning	• View my video explaining the development and use of an effective Positioning Statement
Storyboarding	• View my video explaining the purpose and process of storyboarding, placing the tool in the context of New Venture Creation.
Sweetwater	• Prepare the Sweetwater case for discussion in my next In-Person Session. • Consider these preparatory questions: ◦ Using your own perspective (and those of your hiking friends), what are the important customer needs in the water purifier market? In other words, what characterizes an outstanding concept for a water purification device for the outdoors?

	○ How would you structure these needs to best serve the concept design process? Why? ○ What does Sandy Platter need to do now? ○ What should be the Sweetwater product positioning? Will this be an easy or a tough sell? Why? ○ What should be the focus of subsequent market research?
Individual Team Meeting Week 5	• As a team, meet with the professor for an initial feedback and advice session, to help you work towards your final concept.

In-Person Session 2 End of Week 6 07 Nov 26	Topics and Preparation
	We will provide details and guidance, and lead exercises and discussions live in the classroom. Be sure that you have completed all of Online Module 2.
Harley-Davidson Case Discussion	We will engage in a case discussion of the Harley-Davidson Posse Ride, the Participants, and how the insights we gain feed the New Venture Creation Process. Be sure that you have prepared the entire case, and be prepared to present your assigned Participant, if your team is selected to present.
Drive-Thru Exercise	We will share and discuss selected videos and Customer Journey Maps, and discuss the realities of using Customer Journey Maps to both analyze existing products and ideate towards new products.
Team Concept Journey Map	In your teams, you will begin to apply the Journey Map and Service Blueprint tools we are learning to find more opportunities and generate more ideas for your own team project, and to iterate towards an even more compelling Customer Experience. You will continue building upon this in Online Module 3.
Sweetwater Case Discussion	We will engage in a case discussion of Sweetwater, the Participants, and how the insights we gain feed the New Venture Creation Process. Be sure that you have prepared the entire case, drawing upon the preparatory questions above as a starting point for discussion.
Team Concept Storyboards	In your teams, you will begin to apply the Storyboard tool, alongside the other tools we are learning, to iterate upon and improve your Concept. You will continue building upon this in Online Module 3, feeding into your Final Presentation.

Online Module 3	Topics and Assignments
Team Project Concept	- Based upon the peer and instructor critique, revise the Concept that you are developing. - You will find it most productive to do this in parallel with the Journey Map exercise below. - Upload your revised Concept to Canvas.
Team Concept Journey Map	- Continuing the exercise begun in the previous In-Person Session, construct an ideal Customer Journey Map for your concept. Upload to Canvas for peer critique. - Review and critique your chosen team's submission. Use the rubric attached to the assignment in Canvas to guide your critique. Instructors will synthesize and provide feedback.
Team Project Concept	- Based upon the peer and instructor critique, revise the Concept that you are developing. - You will find it most productive to do this in parallel with the storyboard exercise below. - Upload your revised Concept to Canvas.
Team Concept Storyboards	- Continuing the exercise begun in the previous In-Person Session, construct storyboards for your concept. Remember that the storyboard can be used at both a high-level to work through the experience as a whole, and at a low-level, to focus on the details of how value is actually created and delivered. Upload to Canvas for peer critique. - Review and critique your chosen team's submission. Use the rubric attached to the assignment in Canvas to guide your critique. Instructors will synthesize and provide feedback.
Market Research	- View my video providing an overview of the types of market research, and discussing various techniques useful in the New Venture Creation process. - View my video discussing Surveys, how to construct an effective survey, and a few examples that help us evaluate the likely effectiveness of a survey. - View my video discussing the topic of correlation vs causation, and exploring the construction and use of causal research. - View my video discussing a quantitative approach to segmentation and persona development, and demonstrating its application to the development of real products. - Participate in the online conjoint analysis survey for smart watches. - View my video discussing the tool of conjoint analysis and its application to the development of real products..

Survey	- Construct and upload to Canvas a short survey that tests the most important assumptions in your Concept: - Define your goals – what do you want to test? - Design the structure and content of the questions you want to ask - Consider the medium - Keep the length of the survey feasible and practical - Review and critique your chosen team's submission. Instructors will synthesize and provide feedback.
Individual Team Meeting Week 9	As a team, meet with the professor for a second feedback and advice session, to continue helping you work towards your final concept.
Final Presentation / Concept Pitch	- View my video discussing the purpose and elements of a Concept Pitch, and expectations for the Final Presentation. - As a team, craft a presentation of your concept. - Include, as appropriate, the insights, positioning, testing, and learnings that support your concept as desirable and viable. - Submit your presentation on Canvas. - You will have a maximum of 5 minutes to present live in our next In-Person Session

In-Person Session 3 End of Week 10 05 Dec 26	Topics and Preparation
	We will provide details and guidance, and lead exercises and discussions live in the classroom. Be sure that you have completed all of Online Module 4.
Final Presentations	In your teams, you will deliver your Final Presentation / Concept Pitch, a maximum of 5 minutes, live to the instructors and your classmates. You and your classmates will evaluate the Concepts and Pitches using a rubric.
Wrap-up	We will wrap-up the quarter, tying together both the specific tools we have learned and the overall framework of New Venture Creation, showing how this leads into the next steps of detailed development for your business as a whole and for the actual product you deliver to customers.